

Kinematic Basis of the Linkage Simulator Prototype

Implementation-derived technical note

1 Scope and conventions

The prototype is a deterministic planar kinematics demonstrator, not a dynamic or biomechanical model. World coordinates use millimetre-like units, angles use radians internally, and positive angles are counter-clockwise. A rigid link of length L has a centre pose $(\mathbf{p}, \theta)$ and local endpoints $(-L/2, 0)$ and $(L/2, 0)$. A local point $\mathbf{q}$ maps to world space as

$$\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{p} + R(\theta)\mathbf{q}, \quad R(\theta) = \begin{bmatrix} \cos \theta & -\sin \theta \\ \sin \theta & \cos \theta \end{bmatrix}. \quad (1)$$

The data model permits arbitrary collections of links and revolute joints. The first solver strategy is deliberately narrower: one four-bar topology identified by stable component IDs.

2 Dorsal mounting geometry

Let $\mathbf{G}$ be a point on the dorsal hand-adjacent ground plane, with unit tangent $\mathbf{t}_g$ and dorsal normal $\mathbf{n}_g$. The editable servo-ground offset h places the servo axis at

$$\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{G} + h\mathbf{n}_g. \quad (2)$$

The fixed dorsal rail has editable length L_g and servo-relative angle α_g . Its second endpoint, which grounds the proximal rocker, is

$$\mathbf{D} = \mathbf{A} + L_g(\cos \alpha_g, \sin \alpha_g). \quad (3)$$

Thus the rocker anchor is visibly structural rather than a floating ground symbol. Repositioning the servo preserves the ground-plane normal reference; editing h , L_g , or α_g deterministically rebuilds both ground pivots before the mechanism solve.

3 Analytic four-bar solve

Let $\mathbf{A}$ be the servo pivot, $\mathbf{D}$ the rocker ground pivot, and r_1, r_2, r_3 the crank length, crank-to-rocker joint distance along the coupler, and rocker length. Both ground pivots are dorsal and proximal to the D2 metacarpal; there is no distal ground pivot. Given servo angle ϕ , the crank endpoint is

$$\mathbf{B} = \mathbf{A} + r_1(\cos \phi, \sin \phi). \quad (4)$$

The floating output joint $\mathbf{C}$ must satisfy

$$\|\mathbf{C} - \mathbf{B}\| = r_2, \quad \|\mathbf{C} - \mathbf{D}\| = r_3. \quad (5)$$

It is therefore obtained from the intersection of two circles. The geometry routine explicitly distinguishes separate, contained, tangent, two-solution, coincident, concentric, and negative-radius cases. For two solutions, the solver chooses the candidate nearest the preceding valid $\mathbf{C}$. This local continuity rule preserves the assembly branch during a servo sweep without embedding a fixed “upper” or “lower” branch rule.

The output joint $\mathbf{C}$ is not grounded to the anatomy. Instead, a short structural anchor leaves it at fixed coupler-relative offset δ :

$$\mathbf{E} = \mathbf{C} + L_a \begin{bmatrix} \cos(\theta_c + \delta) \\ \sin(\theta_c + \delta) \end{bmatrix}, \quad \theta_c = \text{atan2}(C_y - B_y, C_x - B_x). \quad (6)$$

Two revolute rectangular drivers continue from $\mathbf{E}$: one carries the middle-phalanx contactor, and the second has an ungrounded right endpoint and carries the distal contactor. This split accommodates two dorsal contacts without introducing an anatomical distal ground attachment.

When no finite intersection exists, only the crank pose is updated. The previous valid coupler and rocker poses remain available for rendering and the state is marked invalid. No non-finite values enter the render loop.

4 Simultaneous finger and contactor solve

The index finger is a serial proximal–middle–distal chain. DIP flexion is coupled to PIP flexion by $\gamma = k\beta$, with $k = 0.62$. For contactor j , let $\mathbf{F}_j(\alpha, \beta)$ be its point on the finger centreline and $\mathbf{n}_{d,j}$ the segment normal directed toward positive world Y . The required linkage centreline point is

$$\mathbf{T}_j = \mathbf{F}_j + \left(\frac{w_{f,j}}{2} + \frac{w_{l,j}}{2} + c_j \right) \mathbf{n}_{d,j}, \quad (7)$$

where c_j is band clearance. The unknown vector $\mathbf{z} = (\alpha, \beta, \eta_m, \eta_d)$ contains MCP and PIP angles plus the two passive driver angles. With $\mathbf{P}_m(\mathbf{z})$ and $\mathbf{P}_d(\mathbf{z})$ denoting the two linkage contact points, the default solve drives the four residuals

$$\mathbf{r}(\mathbf{z}) = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{P}_m - \mathbf{T}_m \\ \mathbf{P}_d - \mathbf{T}_d \end{bmatrix} = \mathbf{0}. \quad (8)$$

A bounded Newton iteration uses a finite-difference 4×4 Jacobian and the previous valid pose as its initial state. This is a determinate positional IK; no artificial joint stiffness or force model is introduced. Rendering places a rectangular pad dorsal to each digit segment and a U-shaped band down to the flexor side.

Every rectangular link is also tested against each phalanx capsule. For link centreline segment S_l , finger centreline segment S_f , link width w_l , finger width w_f , and clearance ϵ , a pose is admissible only if

$$\text{dist}(S_l, S_f) \geq \frac{w_l + w_f}{2} + \epsilon. \quad (9)$$

The contact solve includes each link half-width in its dorsal offset, so the intended bars remain outside the finger capsules. Links are also tested against the finite dorsal ground-plane segment and base rail. Within the rail’s longitudinal span, a signed half-plane test prevents a servo-driven link from passing to the hand-side of the rail even when it does not intersect the rail. Intended servo and rocker pivot coincidences are permitted; other rail crossings or capsule overlaps are rejected. Rejection restores the last valid link, hand, mount, and contact configuration.

5 Inverse endpoint controls

Each rectangular link exposes its positive-local- x endpoint as a control handle. Dragging the crank handle directly sets and clamps the servo angle. For constrained four-bar, anchor, middle-driver, and distal-driver handles, the prototype samples the servo ROM and selects the valid angle whose endpoint is nearest the pointer target. This bounded one-dimensional inverse solve preserves the same forward solver as the source of truth. An unconstrained imported link instead rotates about its left endpoint.

User-added links are never floating: creation requires an underlying link or servo context and atomically creates a revolute joint at the new rectangle’s left endpoint. Passive parent–child attachments are propagated after the main four-bar solve so their joint locations follow moving parent links. The optional construction layer renders the full radius- L locus centred on the live left joint of every nonfixed rectangular link, including the anchor, middle, and distal drivers. These centres update after parent constraints, so the displayed circles and the solved joint closures share the same poses.

6 Update ordering and invariants

Simulation time advances independently from drawing. The servo sweeps between its configured limits, reflecting direction at each limit, before the analytic mechanism and finger solves run. Rendering is read-only with respect to mechanism state. The principal invariants are: link poses remain finite; solved endpoint distances agree with link lengths up to floating-point tolerance; and branch choice is based only on the previous valid configuration.

7 Next mathematical milestone

A general constraint graph should replace the four-bar strategy. A practical next step is a graph traversal that resolves analytically solvable dyads and reports degrees of freedom, disconnected components, singularities, and overconstraints. Numerical residual minimization can then serve as a bounded fallback, with the analytic result and prior frame used as its initial condition.